

High-Level Leader Visits: A Promising Area of Study in IR

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Abstract: Once deemed a “nearly impossible” area of study, high-level leader visits—one of the most visible and consequential practices in global politics—have recently attracted renewed scholarly attention. This resurgence stems from the growing recognition of leader visits as a valuable lens for addressing foundational questions in international relations, including why states act as they do, the consequences of their actions, and how their behavior shapes their global standing. By mapping the current research landscape on leader visits, we highlight its potential for advancing theoretical frameworks and methodological approaches. To further develop this field, we advocate for innovative research methodologies, new avenues of inquiry, and enhanced data collection efforts, paving the way for deeper and more systematic analyses of leader visits in global politics.

Resumen: Las visitas de líderes de alto nivel, una de las prácticas más visibles y con más consecuencias de la política global, y que llegaron a ser consideradas un área de estudio «casi imposible», (Brams, 1969: 266) han atraído recientemente una renovada atención académica. Este resurgimiento se deriva del creciente reconocimiento de las visitas de los líderes como una lente valiosa para abordar cuestiones fundamentales en las relaciones internacionales, incluyendo cuestiones como: por qué los Estados actúan de la forma que lo hacen, las consecuencias de sus acciones y cómo su comportamiento da forma a su posición global. Mapeamos el panorama actual de la investigación relativa a las visitas de los líderes y destacamos su potencial para avanzar en los marcos teóricos y los enfoques metodológicos. Abogamos, con el fin de desarrollar aún más este campo, por metodologías de investigación innovadoras, nuevas vías de investigación y mejores esfuerzos de recopilación de datos, allanando, de esta manera, el camino para poder llevar a cabo análisis más profundos y sistemáticos de las visitas de líderes en la política global.

Résumé: Autrefois considérées comme un domaine d'étude « presque impossible » (Brams, 1969 : 266), les visites de dirigeants de haut niveau—l'une des pratiques les plus importantes et visibles en politique mondiale—font depuis peu l'objet d'un regain d'intérêt de la part des chercheurs. Cette recrudescence procède d'une reconnaissance croissante des visites de dirigeants comme un angle précieux pour traiter de questions fondamentales en relations internationales : Pourquoi les États agissent-ils comme ils le font ? Quelles sont les conséquences de leurs actions ? Comment leur comportement façonne-t-il leur position sur la scène internationale ? En représentant le paysage actuel de la recherche sur les visites de dirigeants, nous mettons en lumière son potentiel quand il s'agit de faire progresser les cadres théoriques et les approches méthodologiques. En vue de développer plus avant ce domaine, nous recommandons des méthodologies de recherche innovantes, de nouvelles pistes de recherche et un renouvellement des efforts de collecte de données, afin de faciliter des analyses plus approfondies et systématiques des visites de dirigeants en politique mondiale.

Keywords: practice, leader visits, diplomacy, foreign policy, global governance, political communication, international relations theory, empirical IR

Palabras clave: práctica, visitas de líderes, diplomacia, política exterior, gobernanza global, comunicación política, teoría de las relaciones internacionales, RRII empíricas

Mots clés: pratique, visites de dirigeants, diplomatie, politique étrangère, gouvernance mondiale, communication politique, théorie des relations internationales, RI empiriques

Introduction: Leader Visit Studies

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First emerging in the late 1960s and early 1970s, the study of high-level leader visits primarily approached foreign travels as indicators showing affinity among states. However, it remained a marginal topic, receiving attention in only a limited number

of scholarly works (e.g., [Models](#) 1968; [Hughes and Volgy](#) 1970). A renewed interest in the 1990s, which treated leader visits as an independent variable (IV), shifted the focus to the domestic policy implications of such visits, albeit predominantly within the US context (e.g., [Brace and Hinckley](#) 1993). A persistent challenge during the first two waves of interest was the systematic collection of visit data. A major breakthrough occurred in 1999 with the release of official US visit data by the Office of the Historian, which provided comprehensive and accurate records. This milestone, combined with advancements in digital technologies such as computers and the Internet that significantly facilitated data collection and a growing interest among international political economy (IPE) scholars in the relationship between leader visits and trade, collectively triggered a third wave of research in the 2010s ([Nitsch](#) 2007). This new wave shifted the focus toward treating visits as both dependent variable (DV) and IVs, leading to a surge in studies published in prominent academic journals, primarily examining US and Chinese leader visits (e.g., [Kastner and Saunders](#) 2012; [Lebovic and Saunders](#) 2016). By the 2020s, the literature on leader visits had broadened significantly, extending beyond the United States and China to encompass diverse national contexts and include visits by non-state actors, while also deepening through the application of increasingly sophisticated analytical methods.

The third wave of leader visit studies is not merely driven by the pursuit of a novel topic but stems from the unique advantages high-level visits offer in understanding interstate relations. Unlike other acts in international politics, such as wars, agreements, or sanctions, leader visits occur far more frequently and exhibit considerably greater diversity. Their frequency and variation provide a rich dataset that allows for more nuanced analyses of the factors and *motivations* influencing state behavior ([Balci](#) 2024a). States employ a variety of strategies to achieve their objectives in international politics, such as opening new embassies, providing foreign aid, and engaging in military exercises. Compared to these strategies, leader visits are relatively less costly, capable of attracting significant public and media attention, and directly conveying a state's intentions, making them an effective tool for achieving desired *outcomes*. As such, leader visits represent a compelling avenue for scholarly inquiry, offering unique insights into how states pursue and realize their diplomatic, economic, and strategic aims. Finally, leader visits offer distinct advantages over traditional *indicators* of interstate relations, such as alliances, membership in intergovernmental organizations (IGOs), arms transfers, trade relations, and voting patterns in the UN General Assembly ([Balci](#) 2024a; [Kutty and Ladwig](#) 2024). For instance, unlike alliances and IGO memberships, which primarily reflect long-term and institutionalized relationships, leader visits provide a dynamic lens to capture more immediate and short-term fluctuations in bilateral and multilateral relations.

This forum seeks to delve into these issues, fostering discussion on how this new line of inquiry can enhance our understanding of global politics and how we can both deepen and broaden the scope of existing research on leader visits. In this introduction, I will briefly outline three primary objectives of scholars studying leader visits, providing a comprehensive overview of the current state of the literature. While some researchers focus on leader visits to analyze the causes and consequences, others view them as indicators of a state's position within international politics. In essence, leader visits are influenced by certain variables, produce specific outcomes, and signify particular strategic positions. At the same time, the study of leader visits offers fertile ground for theoretical advancement, engaging with core debates in international relations. From a realist perspective, visits serve as instruments of power projection and alliance management, while liberal approaches highlight their role in fostering economic and institutional cooperation. Constructivist and practice-oriented perspectives, in turn, emphasize the performative and symbolic dimensions of visits, shaping diplomatic norms and perceptions of legitimacy. By framing leader visits within these broader theoretical debates, this forum

seeks to contribute not only to empirical research but also to the conceptual refinement of high-level visits as a field of inquiry.

Determinants

To explore the motivations behind leaders' travels, [Lebovic and Saunders \(2016, 108\)](#) proposed a compelling theoretical framework anchored in three perspectives: strategic interests, domestic influences, and international practices. This framework suggests that leaders tailor their travel decisions to advance their states' strategic objectives, shaped by domestic dynamics and often guided by past visits. Subsequent research treating leader visits as the DV has predominantly tested these theoretical assumptions, with findings largely reinforcing Lebovic and Saunders' conclusions ([Koliev and Lundgren 2021](#); [Kutty and Ladwig 2024](#)). While some studies have introduced constructivist insights, examining identity ([Balci and Pulat 2024](#)) and international organization solidarity ([Wang and Stone 2023](#)), the literature remains predominantly focused on strategic interests and domestic factors. If this trajectory persists, the field risks evolving into a predominantly empirical domain that reaffirms the arguments of neoclassical realist theory. It is therefore unsurprising that the determinants of leader visits are often encapsulated within three overarching levels: strategic interests, domestic politics, and individual characteristics (see Kim's contribution in this forum). However, this narrow focus limits the potential of leader visit studies to test broader theoretical assumptions. Leader visits present a valuable opportunity to explore key propositions from nonmainstream theories, leading to a richer understanding of the diverse factors influencing high-level interactions.

Empirical studies that move beyond state leaders to examine visits by non-state actors provide a valuable opportunity to test the propositions of liberal theory. The ideological orientations of leaders and the characteristics of the regimes they govern offer critical insights into the types of visits they prioritize, which sheds light on how ideological dynamics shape diplomatic engagements. While the existing literature often prioritizes bilateral visits over multilateral ones, participation in international organization platforms offers a distinct perspective to analyze ideological alignments and group dynamics among states. Woo's contribution in this forum broadens our understanding of the former, while Baturu's work highlights the importance of multilateral visits, demonstrating how such engagements are often influenced by regime-related dynamics. These theoretical expansions are by no means exhaustive. For instance, feminist theory suggests that male and female leaders may exhibit different visit preferences, while the English School emphasizes the influence of historical legacies on diplomatic choices. As an illustration, the colonial histories of European powers in Africa may inform their contemporary patterns of visits to the continent. While not their primary focus, [McManus and Nieman \(2019\)](#) demonstrate that colonial history is a positive and significant predictor of signals of support, including visits, by Russia, Britain, and France to smaller states.

Expanding country cases beyond the usual focus on the United States and China offers the potential for richer theoretical insights (see Moyer et al.'s chapter in this forum). Smaller states, which place greater emphasis on legitimacy considerations ([Balci 2024b](#)), offer valuable opportunities for exploring the nonmaterial determinants of leader visits. Broadening the dataset to include these states can enhance our understanding of the factors shaping visit patterns. However, while such efforts make leader visits a promising area for testing diverse theoretical frameworks, simply expanding the range of determinants may not yield deeper insights into the underlying causes. A potential solution to this inflation of variables is the adoption of a gravity model ([Anderson and van Wincoop 2003](#)). This model posits that larger countries—defined by GDP, military power, or population—are more likely to attract visits, while factors such as distance and cultural differences diminish this

likelihood. Despite the implicit alignment of many studies with this framework, the lack of a standardized benchmark for leader visit patterns has resulted in inconsistent applications of gravity variables. Establishing such consistency is essential, as unexpected findings, like a negative correlation between GDP and visits, could either challenge the model's validity or uncover new dimensions of leader visit behavior.

Outcomes

Unlike studies approaching leader visits as the DV, the literature examining leader visits as the IV has been primarily dominated by political economy scholars, contributing significantly to the body of work on “economic diplomacy.” This well-established literature demonstrates that leader visits can stimulate bilateral trade, attract foreign direct investment (FDI), and facilitate the flow of foreign aid (for a review, see [Kodila-Tedika and Khalifa 2024](#)). Beyond economic outcomes, recent research in political science and international relations has demonstrated the potential of leader visits to reduce regional conflicts ([Lindsey and Hobbs 2015](#)), improve human rights records ([Endrich and Gutmann 2024](#)), deter external aggression ([McManus 2018](#)), bolster incumbent support ([Malis and Smith 2021](#)), reassure allies ([Blankenship 2020](#)), enhance foreign public opinion ([Goldsmith, Horiuchi, and Matush 2021](#)), realign bilateral relationships ([Wang 2022](#)), and influence the domestic or foreign policy choices of the host state ([Oztig and Karluk 2025](#)). Furthermore, a separate strand of scholarship focuses on the impact of leaders' international travel on their domestic approval ratings (for a review, see [Goldsmith, Horiuchi, and Matush 2024](#), 4–5).

The literature using leader visits as an IV exhibits stronger analyses of causal mechanisms compared to studies treating visits as a DV. For example, studies examining the link between visits and leader approval go beyond mere correlation, exploring the causal pathways connecting visits to changes in approval ratings. Unlike domestic travel, which can often be perceived as partisan, foreign visits allow leaders to project an image of national unity, positioning themselves as symbolic representatives of the nation as a whole ([Brace and Hinckley 1993](#), 384). Consequently, studies often investigate whether such trips garner increased media attention and whether the media's portrayal is positive ([Simon and Ostrom 1989](#), 61). Research focusing on the deterrence effect of great power visits attempts to elucidate the informational mechanisms linking such visits to state survival. Conversely, the IV literature focusing on noneconomic outcomes often neglects the experiences of smaller states. It is plausible, however, that foreign visits exert a more pronounced influence on domestic politics in smaller states ([Matush 2023](#); [Balci 2024b](#)). For instance, the visibility of a leader from a smaller state on the international stage may enhance their domestic image, projecting an aura of authority and competence in the eyes of their constituents (see Baturu's paper in this forum).

Establishing clear causal connections between leader visits and their outcomes, however, remains a significant analytical challenge. While incorporating declared intentions into the analysis may help clarify these relationships, many visits are driven by multiple—sometimes covert—motivations. For instance, a visit to a smaller state facing domestic or external threats may ostensibly signal support for an ally but could also serve as an opportunity to extract concessions from a state in need of assistance. Moreover, assuming a direct correlation between visits and intentions to support an ally is overly simplistic. This assumption neglects the reputational risks associated with engaging with leaders who may soon be removed from office ([Malis and Smith 2021](#), 242). Great power leaders are more likely to visit counterparts whose positions appear politically secure, suggesting that the severity of threats faced by a smaller state influences the likelihood of a visit. The desire to minimize reputational costs may deter great power leaders from engaging with states

experiencing significant domestic instability. These complexities underscore the need for rigorous qualitative research, particularly archival analysis (e.g., [Mücke 2021](#); [Balci 2025](#)), to provide deeper contextual insights that can refine and enhance quantitative models. Contributions of Holmes and Moyer et al. further emphasize the importance of qualitative studies on leader visits, both as a DV and IV.

Indicators

Despite their analytical value, leader visits remain underexamined as indicators of state relations, national status, and even leaders' inclinations. A vast body of literature has focused on shifts in foreign policy orientations by analyzing changes in voting patterns within international organizations, alliance commitments, trade partnerships, and arms procurement trends. However, the distribution and direction of high-level leader visits offer a significant yet often overlooked indicator of which states are perceived as important, which are recognized as great powers, and how foreign relations evolve over time. Although only a handful of studies have explored leader visits as an indicator of ideological alignment or regional belonging ([Modelski 1968](#); [Brams 1969](#); [Hughes and Volgy 1970](#); [Thompson 1981a](#)), [Kastner and Saunders \(2012\)](#) revitalized scholarly interest in this approach. Their analysis of Chinese leaders' foreign visits assesses whether Beijing has sought to challenge the US-led international order. A similar model has been applied to India ([Kutty and Ladwig 2024](#)) to track its foreign policy orientation and strategic shifts (for an alternative measurement model, see [Ma and Kang 2023](#)). Other studies have examined leader visits to assess regional status hierarchies and spheres of influence ([Mesquita and Chien 2021](#); [Balci and Pulat 2024](#)).

Although leader visit data offer a flexible and relatively neutral measure of a state's foreign policy priorities ([Goldfien 2024](#)), further research is needed to solidify its use as a robust indicator. Visit frequency alone does not necessarily reflect the strategic importance a visiting country assigns to the host state ([Kutty and Ladwig 2024](#), 5). For instance, some states may prioritize their ties with Washington but are rarely hosted by US leaders, either due to normative concerns or their marginal position within US strategic priorities. Instead, these states may signal allegiance to Washington by visiting key US allies in their region, a dynamic that underscores the need for network-based approaches rather than simple dyadic analyses. Choi's contribution in this forum highlights the importance of visit networks, demonstrating how patterns of diplomatic engagement transcend bilateral relations. Such studies can benefit from engagement with various IR theories. For example, a global cluster analysis of visits could be examined through the world-systems theory, which suggests that interactions between the core and periphery occur primarily through semi-peripheral actors. Moreover, incorporating non-state actors' visit patterns into the analysis can provide further insights into state status and foreign policy orientations (see Woo's contribution). If a country is frequently visited by human rights leaders, for example, this could signal its authoritarian nature or poor democratic record.

The significance of leader visits extends beyond their mere occurrence. The behavior of leaders, their verbal and bodily interactions, and media portrayals during these engagements provide deeper insights that numerical data alone cannot capture. This perspective connects leader visits to critical IR theories, including post-colonialism, poststructuralism, critical constructivism, radical feminism, and practice theory. An emerging body of literature on diplomatic insults ([Rousseau and Baele 2021](#); [Van Rythoven 2022](#)) illustrates how examining the performative aspects of summitry visits can yield valuable insights into both domestic and international political dynamics. Humor, mockery, and satire in leader interactions "both reflect and (re)produce. . . the overlapping structures of power and resistance"

(Brassett, Browning, and Wedderburn 2020, 4). Even asymmetrical diplomatic encounters, such as meetings between foreign ministers and heads of state, can serve as meaningful markers of power hierarchies. In this context, Raythoven and Ku's contribution argues that leader visits should not be viewed as mere statistical occurrences but as manifestations of complex power dynamics and representational strategies.

Path Ahead

Over the past decade, significant strides have been made in collecting and analyzing individual country-level data, leading to substantial progress in the compilation of global leader visit datasets (see Moyer et al.'s chapter). Simultaneously, theoretical and methodological advancements have refined the ways in which this data is examined, enabling more sophisticated analyses (see contributions of Kim and Choi). Beyond bilateral visits, scholars have developed a deeper understanding of multilateral engagements, shedding light on their unique diplomatic and strategic implications (see Baturó's chapter). The scope of leadership analysis has also broadened beyond state leaders, now incorporating non-state actors, such as the UN Secretary-General, whose diplomatic engagements offer valuable insights into global governance dynamics (see Woo's chapter). Additionally, the study of leader visits has evolved beyond quantitative metrics, incorporating the analysis of rituals, bodily performances, and symbolic acts that occur during these visits, enriching our understanding of diplomatic signaling and representation (see Ku and Rythoven's chapter).

Despite these advancements, numerous challenges remain. One notable example is the development of an interaction density index based on leader visits, which offers a promising and innovative metric for assessing the evolution of interstate relations. However, for this approach to serve as a viable alternative to well-established indicators—such as alliances, shared IO memberships, trade volumes, and voting similarity in the UN—it requires not only comprehensive visit data across a wide range of countries but also more nuanced and theoretically informed interpretations. This forum is a modest step in advancing this academic endeavor. Providing a comprehensive review of studies on the determinants of leader visits, Kim highlights that leaders travel not only for state-centric strategic reasons but also to enhance their domestic political standing. His analysis not only calls for deeper theoretical engagement but also challenges simplistic associations between leader visits and state interests. Moyer, Meisel, and McKee present their global leader visit dataset and demonstrate how the disproportionate focus on great and Western powers distorts analytical conclusions.

The following contributions enrich both theoretical and methodological approaches to the study of leader visits. Baturó examines leader attendance at United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), demonstrating how autocrats and democrats alike leverage multilateral platforms for domestic and international gains. He concludes that while such engagements enhance personal diplomacy, they also risk politicizing international organizations. Woo sheds light on a highly overlooked aspect of leader visits—those by non-state actors such as the UN Secretary-General and the Pope. He highlights how their soft power shapes global norms, influences public opinion, and expands diplomacy beyond traditional state actors, often drawing attention to human rights and humanitarian issues. From a methodological perspective, Choi advocates for network analysis, moving beyond dyadic interactions to map diplomatic networks, alliances, and norm diffusion. This approach underscores the interconnected nature of global diplomacy and its broader social dimensions.

Emphasizing qualitative approaches, Ku and Rythoven conceptualize leader visits as performative acts, where rituals, gestures, and emotional expressions

shape perceptions and project authority. Their analysis underscores the symbolic dimensions of diplomacy and how leaders strategically construct their global image. In the concluding section, Holmes highlights some of the most pressing challenges in the study of leader visits, urging scholars to explore the aggregation problem, which explains the difficulty of translating personal trust into policy change; security dilemma sensibility, which reveals the complexities of leader-level diplomacy; and emerging communication technologies, which call for a reassessment of the role of face-to-face interactions in international relations.

Why Do Leaders Travel Abroad? Three Levels in Leader Visit Determinants

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Introduction

Why do political leaders travel abroad? High-level diplomatic exchanges have long been a central and consistent activity in international relations. Some of them, such as Nixon's trip to China and Reagan's visit to the Soviet Union, marked critical turning points in history, from the normalization of long-standing hostilities to the symbolic end of the Cold War. However, beyond a few well-known historical cases, scholars still lack a unified framework for understanding the broader determinants of leadership visits. Leaders could have delegated meetings to professional diplomats or used phone calls, but they chose to travel abroad in person to make the impact that only their physical presence can produce.

Leadership travel operates through two theoretical mechanisms: costs and salience. Visits require substantial time, energy, and opportunity costs that could have been spent on other political priorities. The very act of traveling signals that the host country holds significant importance for the visiting leader's foreign policy agenda. Visits are also highly salient, both politically and psychologically. Politically, they generate substantial media attention and serve as a clear demonstration of foreign policy achievement to domestic audiences. Psychologically, in-person meetings between top executives foster mutual trust and symbolize a cooperative relationship. But when and why do leaders opt to rely on their costs and salience? This forum chapter systematically examines these determinants using the levels of analysis framework, drawing insights from forty peer-reviewed articles.

Three-Level Determinants of Leadership Visits

Strategic Interests

The dominant scholarly perspective suggests that strategic considerations, and the strengthening of bilateral economic and security ties are key drivers of high-level diplomatic visits. One of the most common motivations for leadership travel is, unsurprisingly, economic: facilitating foreign trade deals and investment. Many heads of state's primary destinations are typically wealthy, fast-growing, and major trading partners (e.g., [Lebovic and Saunders 2016](#); [Koliev and Lundgren 2021](#); [Wang and Stone 2023](#); [Balci and Pulat 2024](#); [Aras and Faziloglu 2025](#)). Summits often serve as a platform for the official signing of trade deals, followed by an increase in import and export volumes ([Nitsch 2007](#); [Lin, Yan, and Wang 2017](#); [Beaulieu, Lian, and Wan 2020](#)). One side, typically a more powerful state, also attempts to take the opportunity to expand their influence by transferring official development assistance or

government foreign direct investment during their visits to smaller states (Hoshiro 2020; Adam and Tsarsitalidou 2024). Additionally, business executives often accompany political figures during state visits, which enhances economic exchanges in the private sector. In states where governments have strong influence over firms, such as China, state visits can also serve as guidance for state-owned enterprises to increase investment in specific regions (Stone, Wang, and Yu 2022).

Leaders also travel abroad for security purposes. According to the data, leaders are more likely to visit countries that spend more on defense, receive more military aid, are arms sales partners, share formal alliance pacts, and are in crisis (Lebovic and Saunders 2016; Lebovic 2018; Koliev and Lundgren 2021; Balci and Pulat 2024; Lee and Kim 2024). By physically traveling to a foreign state and engaging with its leadership, visiting leaders can send credible signals of shared security interests. This is particularly evident in visits to crisis-affected or allied states, where leaders deliberately tour military bases or issue joint declarations reaffirming security commitments. This strategic process generates deterrent and reassuring effects on the host country (McManus 2018; McManus and Sendić 2024; Kim 2024c).

Beyond economic and security motivations, leadership visits also serve as mechanisms for diplomatic reconciliation, reputation building, and the expansion of global influence. Summits between two former adversaries symbolize normalization and a shift toward friendship (Goldstein 2008; Kim 2024b). Leaders of newly independent or small states visit or invite major power leaders in an effort to gain international recognition and prestige (Balci and Pulat 2024). Leaders of major powers, on the other hand, utilize their presence on foreign soils as a tool for public diplomacy, cultivating a favorable perception of their country among the host nation's citizens and thus strengthening soft power (Goldsmith and Horiuchi 2009; Goldsmith, Horiuchi, and Matush 2021; Wang et al. 2023; Yang et al. 2023). Leaders also travel to influence host countries, persuading them to align with the visiting state's national interests, such as voting similarly at international institutions and maintaining similar political regimes (Kastner and Saunders 2012; Wang 2022; Chen 2023; Balci and Aras 2025).

Domestic Politics

The second group of scholars focused on the domestic political incentives behind leader visits, particularly their effects on public approval. Foreign trips and summits may be expected to have a positive impact on leaders' domestic popularity, as they are carefully planned to ensure political success and reinforce a leader's image as an effective statesperson.

Theoretically speaking, the impact of diplomatic visits on public opinion depends on two variables: whether the leader is hosting or visiting and the relative power dynamics between the two states. Hosting foreign leaders is generally viewed more favorably by domestic audiences, as it signals prestige and influence. This effect is most pronounced when smaller states host leaders from major powers, as it suggests that the visiting leader perceives the host as a valuable partner despite power asymmetries. By contrast, visits by leaders of powerful states to smaller states are expected to have a limited impact on domestic public opinion.

This explains why US presidential visits have historically had minimal effects on domestic approval ratings (Darcy and Richman 1988; Simon and Ostrom 1989; Marra, Ostrom, and Simon 1990). As the world's strongest country, most US presidential visits are not viewed as salient or diplomatic successes. A few high-profile visits to long-standing adversaries like China and Russia can be perceived as major diplomatic breakthroughs, having the potential to shape public opinion. Such visits are thus strategically scheduled during times of domestic unpopularity to be used as a means to improve electoral prospects (Lee and Kim 2024; Kim 2024b).

By contrast, hosting high-level US officials can provide significant political advantages for leaders of smaller countries. Visits from US presidents or top officials not only confer legitimacy but also signal US confidence in the incumbent government (Malis and Smith 2021; Cohen 2022). Domestic audiences in smaller states become more supportive of their government's foreign and defense policies (Wang et al. 2023).

Another strand of research examines how domestic institutional constraints affect when leaders travel more to foreign countries. The overall findings suggest that leaders travel more frequently when they have less bargaining leverage at home. For example, US presidents travel more often during divided government when they lack Congress control, won the presidential election by a small margin, and have low public approval (Potter 2013; Cavari and Ables 2019; Ostrander and Rider 2019). Presidents also travel less in election years because they prioritize domestic affairs over foreign policy, which voters are more concerned about (Doherty 2009; Lebovic and Saunders 2016; Ostrander and Rider 2019). This supports the assumption that foreign travel has opportunity costs, as it takes time and resources that could be spent on domestic issues. Others have focused on the role of a second presidential term. Scholars argue that leaders' foreign travel patterns change in their second term as a result of learning and adapting to reality, a shift in emphasis on leaving a legacy, and concerns about becoming a lame duck (Lebovic and Saunders 2016; Lebovic 2018; Cavari and Ables 2019; Ostrander and Rider 2019; Koliev and Lundgren 2021).

Individual Leaders

The final group of scholars investigates the effect of personal characteristics of individual leaders. There are much fewer studies in this group compared to the first two groups. This is somewhat surprising given the recent surge in leader-level studies and top executives' exclusive authority over diplomacy, among other foreign policies. The most common topic in IR leader studies is how individual-level attributes affect the use of force (Gallagher and Allen 2014; Horowitz and Stam 2014; Barceló 2020; Bertoli, Dafoe, and Trager 2024; Kim 2024a). Leaders have more agency in travel diplomacy decision-making than they do when using military force abroad, increasing the possibility that leader-specific preferences will play a critical role.

This group's literature, despite its small size, falls into two subcategories. The first group focuses on the emotional and psychological effects of face-to-face interactions that occur between leaders and diplomats during visits (Holmes and Yarhi-Milo 2017; Keys and Yorke 2019; Ku and Mitzen 2022). For example, face-to-face diplomacy improves mutual understanding and fosters empathy, increasing the possibility of peace agreement success and shaping how actors at the negotiating table define and pursue national interests.

Another line has shown how leaders' personal characteristics, such as age, partisanship, and interests in foreign affairs, shape diplomatic visit decisions. Aged leaders are less likely to be visited by foreign leaders because their remaining tenure is expected to be short (Malis and Smith 2021). Additionally, although it remains unclear whether the president's partisanship or interests in foreign affairs described in public speeches should be understood as a trait of the leader or the government, there is some evidence that both factors affect levels of engagement in foreign travel (Potter 2013; Ostrander and Rider 2019).

Implications for Future Research

This chapter raises four important questions for future research on high-level travel diplomacy. First, despite the extensive literature on the strategic interests of diplomatic visits, the evidence for the direction of the causal arrow between the two

variables is mixed. Traditionally, political scientists have argued that visits are a byproduct of already improved bilateral relations, while more recent research emphasizes that travel diplomacy has an independent impact on international outcomes. The mixed results may reflect the varied use of diplomatic visits in practice. Future research can delve deeper into the specific conditions under which states use travel diplomacy to achieve specific goals or whether it is simply a ceremonial event to demonstrate the direction both governments have already begun to move.

Second, one issue in the domestic influences approach is the presence of many conflicting findings, such as the impact of US leadership visits on host leaders' approval at home and the relationship between divided government or lame-duck status and the amount of foreign travel. This could be due to differences in how scholars operationalize key variables, such as the type of leader (e.g., heads of state or ministers) and whether the leader is visiting or hosting leaders, as well as the regions, time periods, and research designs used to test their hypotheses. Future scholars can offer more theoretical explanations for different findings across studies and be rigorous in their identification strategies. Additionally, scholars can challenge the assumption that leaders' visits are intended to shape the entire domestic public. Instead, visits may be designed to appeal to specific constituencies, such as diaspora groups with strong ties to the host country, when they form a core supporter base for the visiting leader.

Third, research on leader-level variables has been underrepresented in IR leadership visit studies. Do a leader's beliefs, personality, and career background matter? For example, do former professional diplomats or UN Secretary-Generals travel more once they become top executives? One could expect them to do so, given their familiarity with world leaders and their relative strength in diplomacy. Leaders with business experience may also travel more often than others, as they believe they are good at making deals and negotiations. Demographic statuses such as age and gender would influence the amount of travel abroad, as traveling requires a lot of time and energy.

Finally, we need a better model to explain the interaction between different levels of determinants. The three levels of determinants laid out in this chapter may influence leaders' decisions at different times, but they can also operate simultaneously. For example, a war in an allied country may motivate leaders to travel for reassurance, but this effect might be more significant when they face divided government at home. Individual-level factors can also interact with broader structural determinants. Under what conditions are leaders better able to exert greater authority in travel diplomacy? One possible explanation is that during security crises, leaders are expected to make independent decisions that deviate from the established diplomatic practices observed during peacetime.

Building and Maintaining a Global Leader Travel Dataset: Benefits, Challenges, Prospects

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Introduction

World leaders play central roles in shaping interactions among states in the international system. The travel of world leaders is essential for conducting diplomacy

(Goldsmith and Horiuchi 2009), building economic relations (Nitsch 2007), addressing security concerns (McManus 2018), and maintaining bilateral ties (Koliev and Lundgren 2021). Leaders may also use travel to signal status recognition of other leaders and countries (Duque 2018, 582).

Until recently, however, leader travel studies have focused primarily on the United States, China, and European countries, with only a few notable exceptions (e.g., Balci and Pulat 2024). This ignores South-to-South exchanges, which may prove critical for resolving natural resource conflicts (Berry, Kalluri, and Vina 2018), boosting renewable energy technology trade (Gosens 2020), and improving humankind's resilience to future pandemics (Eichbaum et al. 2021).

The Country and Organization Leader Travel (COLT) dataset allows for the exploration of these interactions by cataloguing every observed overseas trip by the primary heads of government and state (HOGS) of more than 200 countries from 1990 to 2023 (Moyer et al. 2025). COLT includes approximately 100,000 travel events involving nearly 4,000 HOGS, enhancing our understanding of patterns in leader diplomacy inclusive of the Global South and potentially furthering discussions on the interrelationship of agency and structure in international relations (IR).

Building COLT comes with many challenges, including resource intensiveness and information sparsity for less prominent leaders and countries with opaque media environments. Despite these challenges, by including the Global South, COLT democratizes diplomatic and IR analysis, allowing researchers to assess leader-level interactions from previously understudied geographic regions in IR (Acharya 2014).

Broadening Study to the Global South

The Global South, a multidimensional categorization encompassing socioeconomic development, geography, and resistance to hegemonic global power (Haug et al. 2021), plays a crucial role in contemporary international politics. Emerging economic powers like Brazil, India, and China are increasingly influencing global economic and political landscapes, contributing to a push for a more balanced distribution of global power (Carranza 2017). This has been accompanied by the BRICS¹ nations' emphasis on multipolarity, fostering increased representation, financial development, and agency for Global South leaders (Cooper and Flemes 2013). These powers' rise has also driven regionalization in international politics through the strengthening of organizations like the African Union and trade agreements like the African Continental Free Trade Area (Geda and Yimer 2022). Together, emerging markets and developing economies now account for nearly 60 percent of global GDP based on purchasing power parity (IMF 2024), underscoring the importance of including the Global South in international analyses to fully understand global dynamics.

However, a lack of comprehensive data on the international travel of Global South leaders prior to the introduction of COLT hindered such understanding. This gap stemmed from several factors, including political and resource constraints, security concerns, and the prioritization of major world powers in research efforts (Acharya 2014).

COLT

Built as a continuous research effort since 2016, COLT is the first global dataset on HOGS travel, with data from 1990 to 2023 that reveal shifting country, regional, and global patterns of leader-level diplomacy and their relationships with trade,

¹Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa.

aid, arms transfers, and other forms of economic and security engagement (Moyer et al. 2025). A detailed description and validation of COLT is provided by Moyer et al. (2025). Here we briefly describe key patterns relevant to the global study of leader-level diplomacy, including Global South diplomacy. The data-gathering methodology follows other established approaches in IR scholarship (e.g., Moyer, Turner, and Meisel 2021), including the use of translated non-English-language sources available via LexisNexis.

As illustrated in Figure 1, most HOGS stay within their respective regions for overseas travel. Of the more than 22,000 European HOGS overseas trips from 1990 to 2023, for example, roughly 17,000 trips, or roughly 75 percent, were within Europe. Roughly 60 percent of African leaders' overseas trips were within Africa. And roughly half of Asian leaders' overseas trips were within Asia.

If, somewhat coarsely, we consider travel between and within Africa, Asia, Latin America, and Oceania to be intra-Global South leader travel, then a dataset that misses this travel would miss approximately 46 percent of all recorded HOGS overseas trips from 1990 to 2023. Subregional travel patterns largely hold from the regional level. In Africa, for example, only leaders from Southern Africa have traveled more outside than within their subregion from 1990 to 2023 (see, Figure 2).

A more granular picture of leader travel within the Global South may help IR scholars better interrogate a variety of puzzles, including those related to the agents and structure. While COLT cannot solve questions of Global South agency through adding more data or “mak[ing] sense of ‘agency as an analytical problem’” (Pingeot and Pouliot 2024, 6), it can help make sense of Global South leader agency as partly a product of their “embeddedness in a network of links to other entities” (Braun, Schindler, and Willie 2019).

For example, the differences between the overseas travel locations of Nigeria's past three leaders are notable. President Tinubu dedicated one-third of his first nine trips to Arabian Peninsula countries, as illustrated in Table 1. Future research may unpack these trip details, teasing out differences between increasing structural interrelationships between sub-Saharan Africa and the Middle East versus agent-level factors and motivations for travel. Leaders' religious affinities, for example, do not appear to be a decisive factor, as both Tinubu and his predecessor are Muslim. More apparent is Tinubu's overlapping tenure with a period of flowering Middle East–Africa relations, largely a product of aid, trade, and investment (*The Economist* 2024).

Challenges and Prospects

Commensurate with the benefits of global data on leader travel, there are many challenges. Sparse information, both through spotty media coverage and apparently intentional obfuscation from some leaders, demands a substantial level of effort to overcome. Global South leaders have proven particularly challenging to track.

In COLT, a “confidence rating” variable, assesses a coder's confidence in the information they have coded, extending from 1 (high confidence) to 5 (low confidence), based on a rubric in the COLT coder guide. The average confidence rating for all leaders in COLT is 1.47, with a standard deviation of 0.47. Of the leaders with an average rating more than one standard deviation above the mean in 2023, only five leaders are not from the Global South (see Table 2).

Belize Prime Minister Barrow toward the end of his tenure was another challenging leader to track, where five of his last six trips in office were to unknown countries. Other leaders who traveled overseas to unknown countries, often for “personal visits,” from 1990 to 2023—all from the Global South—are listed in Table 3. In conducting statistical analyses with these data, users would be wise to run models with and without trips coded with low confidence and unknown destinations to assess

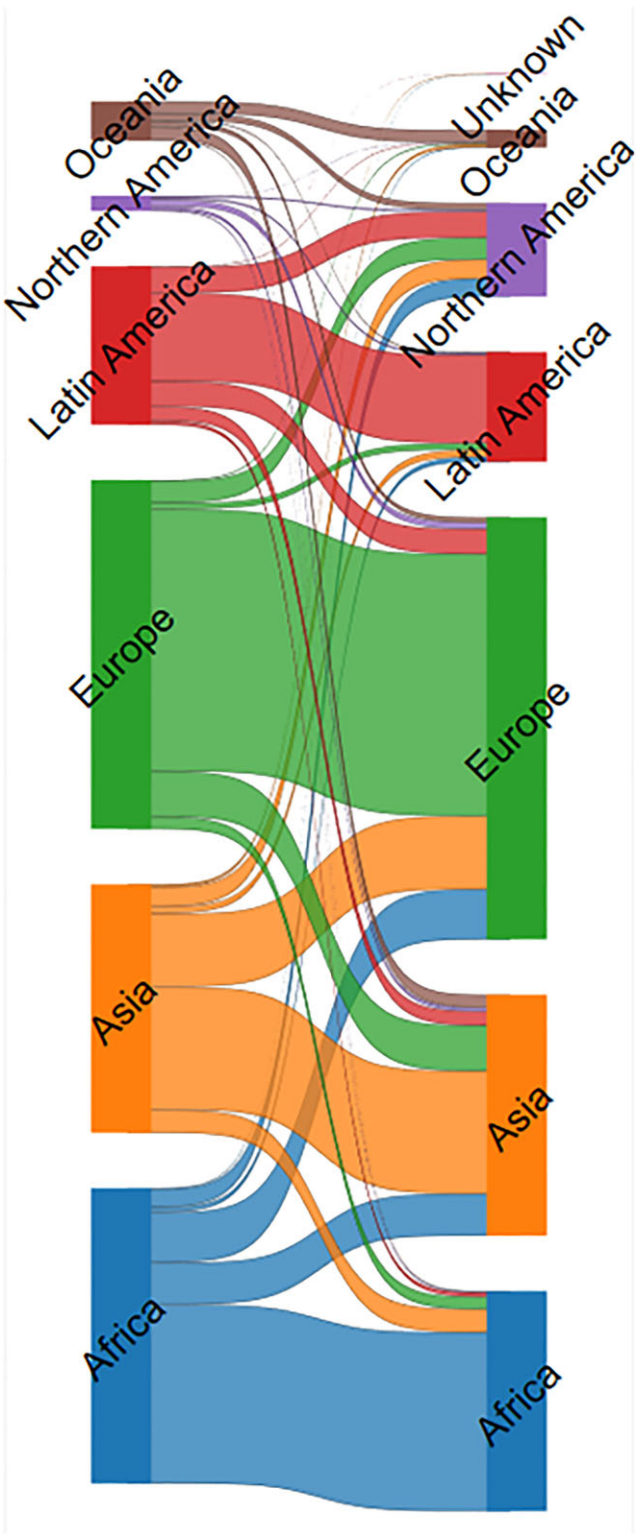


Figure 1. Region-to-region HOGS travel, 1990–2023.

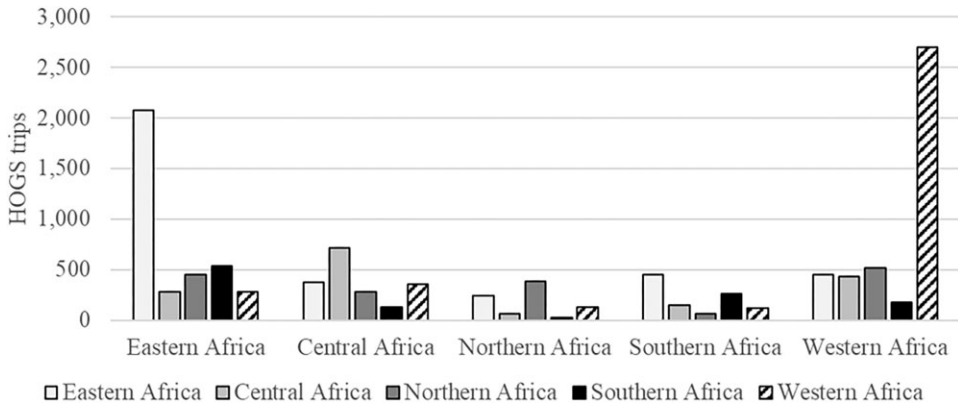


Figure 2. Intraregion HOGS travel in Africa (from x -axis region to legend region), 1990–2023.

Table 1. Travel destinations of Nigeria’s three most-recent leaders in their first 6 months within office

President Jonathan	President Buhari	President Tinubu
Benin	Benin	France
Cabo Verde	Cameroon	Germany
Cameroon	Chad	Guinea-Bissau
Canada	France (x2)	India
France	Germany	Kenya
Gabon	Ghana	Saudi Arabia
Rwanda	India	UAE (x2)
Saudi Arabia	Iran	United States
South Africa	Malta	
Uganda	Niger	
United States (x2)	South Africa	
	Sudan	
	United States (x2)	

whether coefficients meaningfully change. If so, an implication for analysis of the Global South is that additional robustness checks and triangulation with qualitative analytical methods may be required to confirm initial results.

Recognizing that these types of information quality concerns may introduce biases into analysis of Global South leader diplomacy, the COLT project team has begun to increase collaborative efforts with other scholars in the emerging sub-field of leader-level diplomacy. The COLT team has also established an issue tracking system for users of the COLT data to flag potential errors via a publicly accessible form on GitHub.² By making a global dataset of post-Cold War high-level leader travel publicly available and through further interaction with and incorporation of Global South scholarship, the COLT project seeks to lay the foundation for a truly international study of often Western-focused “international” relations.

²Available here: <https://github.com/PardeeCenterDU/Diplometrics-data-issue-tracker>.

Table 2. COLT leaders in 2023 with below-average confidence ratings for the information recorded about their overseas travel

Country	Leader	Average confidence rating
Burkina Faso	Interim President Traore	2
Czechia	President Zeman	2.23
Grenada	Prime Minister Mitchell	2.31
Kiribati	President Maamau	2.03
Malta	Prime Minister Abela	2.11
Nauru	President Adeang	2
Saint Kitts and Nevis	Prime Minister Drew	2.04
Saint Lucia	Prime Minister Pierre	2.11
Samoa	Prime Minister Mata'afa	2
San Marino	Captain Regent Berti	2
San Marino	Captain Regent Troina	2.5
San Marino	Captain Regent Tamagnini	3
Tajikistan	President Rahmon	1.99
Tuvalu	Prime Minister Natano	1.94

Table 3. Frequency of COLT leader travel to unknown countries from 1990 to 2023

Country	Leader	Count of trips
Jordan	King Abdullah II	19
Cameroon	President Biya	10
UAE	President Al Nahyan	7
Belize	Prime Minister Barrow	5
Azerbaijan	President Aliyev	4
Zimbabwe	President Mugabe	3
Algeria	President Bouteflika	1
Armenia	President Sarkisyan	1
Costa Rica	President Pacheco	1
Seychelles	President Ramkalawan	1

Why Do Leaders Attend the United Nations and Other International Fora? Leader Visits, Rhetoric, and Consequences for Multilateralism

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What explains the growing tendency of national political leaders to attend and address international organizations (IOs) and global summits, and what difference does it make? This section focuses on the prestige- and domestic politics-driven logics of leaders’ visits to the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), also discussing the likely implications of such leaders’ attendance on the quality of deliberation in the global forum. It also outlines possible directions for further research into leaders’ attendance of other IOs and summits, beyond the UNGA.

Research to date has tended to ignore the distinction between high-profile national representatives at IOs, assuming no significant difference in terms of how they represent or express state preferences and interests. While during the Cold

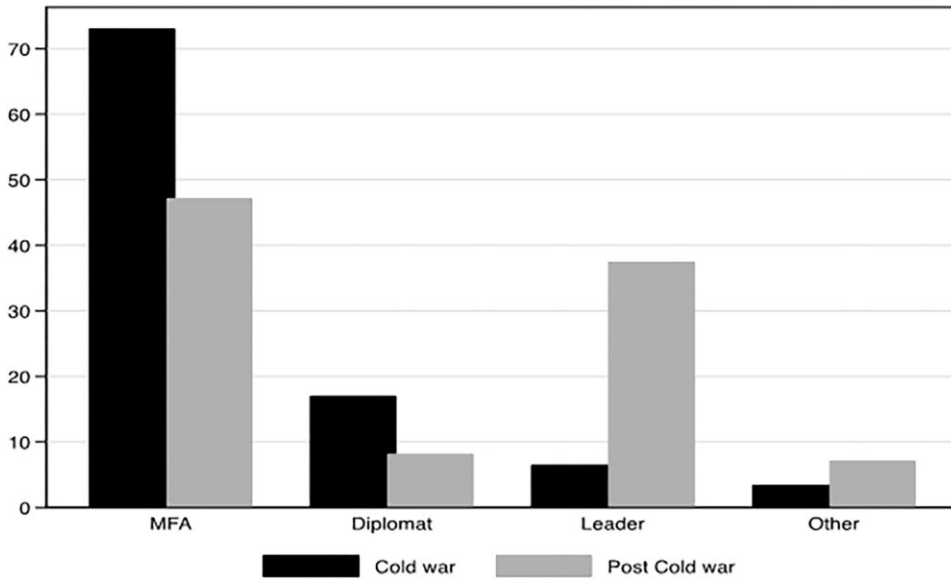


Figure 3. Attendance of the opening session of the UNGA, 1946–2022.

Note. Data from [Baturu and Gray \(2024b\)](#).

War international fora, such as the UNGA, were dominated by diplomats and foreign ministers, nowadays more and more leaders are choosing to present themselves at the international stage. Drawing and synthesizing findings from recent research regarding the causes and consequences of leaders' visits to the UNGA, this section cautions against expectations for necessarily net positive effects of leaders' multilateral engagements. Based on the evidence from the UNGA, leaders' visits appear to be primarily driven by considerations of prestige and herd behavior, as well as domestic politics' concerns. In turn, while leaders' attendance of the UNGA may potentially generate more publicity for the meetings, their presence also diminishes the quality of diplomatic communication and debate, as leaders primarily seek publicity and tend to neglect the complexity of multilateral cooperation in speech.

Leader and Non-Leader Visits to the UNGA

Each regular session of the UNGA begins with its showpiece, the general debate, widely covered by the media ([Keens-Soper 1985](#); [Baturu, Dasandi, and Mikhaylov 2017](#); [Jankin, Baturu, and Dasandi 2024](#), 80). Then, national delegations are represented by political leaders, foreign ministers, heads of diplomatic missions, as well as others, including ministers or even, in autocracies, the leader's relatives ([Gray and Baturu 2021](#)). In 2022, the debate was attended by 111 national political leaders, or almost 60 percent of all representatives. Such a strong presence by leaders has not been the case in the past, however.

Figure 3 shows that during the Cold War, the UN opening session was predominantly attended by either foreign ministers or diplomats. This has dramatically changed after 1990, when political leaders have increasingly turned to represent their countries. As demonstrated by [Baturu and Gray \(2024b, 159–61\)](#), it was not the end of the Cold War that triggered this notable change; rather, it happened later, following the 2000 UN Millennium and 2005 World Summits, which normalized the summitry for leaders, including visiting regular sessions of the assembly in the years that follow. Furthermore, the leaders' increased presence at the UNGA

is not driven by democratic leaders alone as over a third of attending leaders are autocrats now.

The Logic of Attendance

The general explanation for leaders' UNGA attendance is twofold, driven by the prestige- and domestic politics-driven logics. First, leaders are attracted to it because visiting the most lustrous global forum gets to be increasingly seen as a norm; it allows leaders to enhance their standing by rubbing shoulders with other heads of state, including from powerful and donor nations; that is, the more heads of state in attendance, the stronger the impetus for individual leaders not to miss out (Baumeister and Leary 1995). Second, in addition to the logics of peer effects and herd behavior that influence all leaders (Day and Wedderburn 2022), domestic political considerations also hold sway, rendering the attendance less, or more, compelling for particular leaders.

Among such considerations, leaders, democratic and nondemocratic alike, are more likely to attend the UNGA in election years as they can rely on high-profile international appearances to publicize their policy goals and to attract additional publicity. In addition, democratic leaders tend to turn to foreign policy more, and visit the global multilateral forum in years when they are constrained in their domestic policy initiatives by divided government or when they are nearing the end of their terms (Baturó and Gray 2024b). In turn, among autocrats, the most personalized dictators almost never attend the UN because their absence from national capitals often carries risks and may invite attempted coups. Interestingly, most personalized dictators were absent even in 2020 during the global pandemic when the session was held online, possibly indicating that dominance-seeking leaders experience discomfort when they cannot control how they are received by their audiences (Henrich and Gil-White 2001).

In addition to the lure of prestige and domestic considerations, many leaders also seek additional legitimation or policy gains through their visits, but such factors vary across leaders. For instance, leaders under international sanctions in particular often use the international forum to quash appearances of their isolation, showing defiance (Baturó and Tolstrup 2024). Likewise, leaders experiencing domestic legitimacy deficits, whether due to ongoing civil strife, war, or insurgency, often attend the UN in order to drum up support from international allies. Furthermore, as aid and developmental concerns have gained in importance in the assembly (Keens-Soper 1985), leaders from aid-dependent nations have also become more frequent visitors to the UNGA, particularly post-Cold War (Wiseman 2015). One of the sections in this forum proposes that leaders' international travel needs to be understood through the prism of network analysis. One promising area of future research is to explore various network considerations driving leaders' visits in connection to international development concerns, that is, whether heads of the least developed nations are more likely to attend the UN because of the presence of leaders from important donor nations during particular sessions, or competitive pressures stemming from the attendance of other, similarly aid-dependent leaders, among other reasons.

Further research is also required to investigate the effects of leaders' visits on domestic and international audiences, as many heads of state use the forum to address global audiences, as exemplified, for instance, by the competition between the United States and Soviet leaders during the 1960 session over the sympathies of newly independent states (Keens-Soper 1985; Baturó and Gray 2024b). Scholars can equally explore whether such leaders' visits shape leaders' own perceptions regarding multilateralism: When Nikita Khrushchev's proposals, presented in person in 1959 to reform the UN, have largely fallen on deaf ears, his enthusiasm about international cooperation declined (Baturó and Gray 2024a).

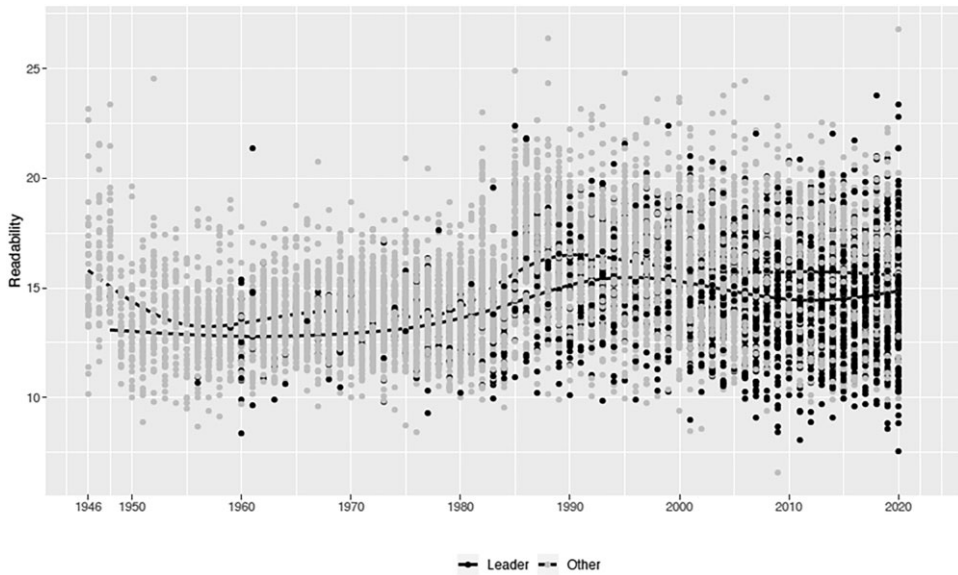


Figure 4. The difference in speech complexity between leaders and other delegates at the UNGA. *Note:* Data from [Jankin, Baturo, and Dasandi \(2024\)](#).

Leaders' and Non-Leaders' Rhetoric and Behavior at the UNGA

From its inception, the UNGA was meant to ensure inclusion and serve as a truly deliberative forum ([Wiseman 2015](#)). The UNGA's "staple method of work is to deliberate not across or around a conference table but through debate" ([Keens-Soper 1985](#), 78). It was intended that the national representatives, through debate, would turn into "reasonable men embodying the reason of the whole" ([Keens-Soper 1985](#), 78). That is, in principle, the assembly's debate was to reflect the most important issues facing the world as a collective "world-of-the-union." And yet, the majority of leaders attending the UNGA are more likely to be driven by considerations over their own policy agendas than those of multilateral cooperation.

Scholars have found that leaders' attendance is not associated with an increase in multilateral initiatives by their country, as evidenced by the lack of a higher likelihood of sponsorship or cosponsorship of resolutions ([Baturo and Gray 2024b](#), 161). Likewise, leaders' visits are not influenced by salient global events. Instead, as seen from their rhetoric, leaders are more interested in their own agendas: In contrast to other types of representatives, heads of state are more distant from the organizational agenda set by the president of the assembly; they also have very few policy topics in common with such presidents; they tend to eschew diplomatic technical language; and they are equally distant from the themes expressed in speeches by the UN Secretary-General—again, in contrast to even their own foreign ministers ([Baturo and Gray 2024a](#)). Whether ministers deviate from their script set by their leaders as principals or different roles at the international stage are assigned strategically, requires further research however.

For an illustration, using the Flesch-Kincaid readability test ([Flesch 1948](#)), with lower scores representing a lower sophistication, [Figure 4](#) shows that throughout the history of the UNGA, on average, leaders have always spoken more plainly than others, and the difference is statistically significant. For instance, post-Cold War, the readability score for the French presidents attending is at 11.4, in contrast to this country's diplomats and ministers' score of 13.0; for Russia, while Yeltsin and Putin's scores are at 13.8, others scores are at 15.7. As leaders have come to

dominate the meetings post-2000, the quality of the debate has also declined, potentially distracting the assembly from its main priorities and away from its parliamentary-style conduct of affairs (United Nations General Assembly 2021).

Implications for Future Research beyond the United Nations

The studies regarding the causes and consequences of leader participation in the UNGA (Gray and Baturó 2021; Baturó and Tolstrup 2024; Baturó and Gray 2024a, b), discussed herein, were able to leverage the recently released data regarding that forum in particular (e.g., Baturó, Dasandi, and Mikhaylov 2017; Jankin, Baturó, and Dasandi 2024). National leaders, however, are known to engage in different types of multilateralism beyond the UNGA. When new systematic sources of data about other forms of summitry, such as regarding various summits or informal IOs of G7 and G20, among others (Kirton 2020), become available, we will be able to improve our understanding of leaders' visits to other important fora. While further research is required, there are reasons to think that the logic of the UNGA attendance, summarized in this section, is not *sui generis*. Thus, scholars who conducted important qualitative studies of G7/G20 meetings (Naylor 2024) and bilateral summitry (Day and Wedderburn 2022), while working from very different theoretical perspectives, have also found evidence in favor of the logic of prestige and herd behavior behind leaders' attendance during summitry in settings beyond the United Nations.

Likewise, leaders' attendance and behavior at other IOs or summits may have similar effects on the quality of deliberation to those observed at the UNGA. That leaders speak plainly is not necessarily always bad, as a simpler language may help to reach wider audiences. However, if leaders' visits, which occur at the expense of other state representatives that usually have stronger domain expertise, are driven by considerations of personal standing or electoral concerns and have the potential to sway the quality of deliberation, then such an increase of leaders' multilateral visits, particularly to smaller IOs with specific policy or technical remits, may unnecessarily politicize such IOs, reducing the efficacy of meetings or multilateral outcomes. That is, leaders visits to the IOs may produce unintended consequences and undermine multilateral efforts.

Causes and Consequences of Visits by Leaders of Non-State Entities: An Emerging Research Agenda

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Introduction

With expanding presence and growing influence of non-state actors in international relations, there are prominent individuals representing non-state entities who regularly travel to countries to meet with politicians, civil society activists, religious leaders, and the public. These leaders are generally recognized for their moral authority, normative commitment, and/or political neutrality. For instance, as the leader of Catholic Church, Pope Francis traveled to six countries including Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, Timor-Leste, Singapore, Belgium, and Luxemburg in first 9 months of

2024.³ During the same period in 2024, the head of the United Nations secretariat, Mr. Antonio Guterres, traveled to twenty-three countries.⁴

Why do leaders of non-state entities pay a visit to countries and what are consequences of those visits? The visits by leaders of non-state entities are carefully planned beforehand and are often used as an opportunity to highlight pressing issues in a country, in a region, or in the world. For instance, when Pope Francis visited Indonesia in September 2024, he emphasized “the messages of interreligious tolerance, unity, and global peace amidst the heightened tension in several parts of the world” (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Indonesia 2024). When the United Nations Secretary General (UNSG) visited Jordan in June 2024, he pleaded for more humanitarian aid for Gaza (United Nations 2024). Are these visits successful in producing intended consequences? Are there any unintended side effects of these visits?

While scholars of international relations have begun paying more attention to causes and consequences of official visits by presidents and prime ministers of a sovereign state for the past few years, far less attention has been paid to leaders of non-state entities and their official visits (Kodila-Tedika and Khalifa 2024; Balci 2024a). Only recently, there have emerged a small number of studies that have explored to which countries leaders of non-state entities travel and what consequences those trips bring about. This chapter seeks to provide an overview of this nascent literature. The next section discusses the theoretical mechanisms through which leaders of non-state entities might make impacts. The following section reviews existing studies on the visits by leaders of non-state entities. The concluding section makes suggestions for future research directions.

Leader of Non-State Entities

Many recent studies in international relations have explored the causes and consequences of leaders' visits focusing on the leaders of major powers, such as the United States and China, then expanding beyond them to include the leaders of smaller powers such as Turkey and South Korea (Kodila-Tedika and Khalifa 2024; Balci 2024a). Approaching from quite diverse theoretical perspectives and analytical frameworks, these studies have enriched our understanding of international relations that have traditionally discounted the roles of individual leaders.

In addition to the leaders of states, there are other high-profile figures in global affairs that may exert substantial influence on various political, economic, and social issues. These leaders include leaders of international organizations, such as the UNSG or the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) and leaders of religious organizations, such as Pope Francis and the Dalai Lama. Exploring possible ways that these leaders can make differences would further enrich our understanding of international affairs beyond the traditional state-centric approach.

At first glance, it is easy to be skeptical and dismiss the role these individuals play in international affairs. After all, leaders of non-state entities command few material resources and must instead rely on sovereign states to raise resources necessary to address various causes in the world. In addition, these visits usually last for only a couple of days, and thus any attention these visits garner might just be too temporary to produce substantial effects.

However, there exist studies that demonstrate the visits by leaders of non-state entities produce intended and unintended consequences, chiefly via normative appeals made by them and increased media attention in and around visit-receiving

³<https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/events/year.dir.html/2024.html>. Accessed December 9, 2024.

⁴<https://www.un.org/sg/en/content/travels>. Accessed December 9, 2024.

countries. During visits by high-profile international figures, local and global media attention given to a visited country intensifies; the leaders tend to strategically utilize the opportunity to push for normative causes, such as promoting human rights and increasing awareness of climate change (Landrum and Vasquez 2020; Laville 2021; Choi et al. 2023; Endrich and Gutmann 2024).

Raised attention from media and the public provides an ample opportunity for non-state entities and their leaders to engage in public diplomacy. For instance, it is often the case that the UNSG holds a press conference at the conclusion of each visit and delivers a carefully chosen message to the public and the press (Choi et al. 2023). Bell and Kitagawa (2024) highlights that both needs and opportunities for public diplomacy are key considerations for OHCHR's state visits. Faith leaders also utilize their visits to promote peace and tolerance among religions (Laville 2021). While not an official visit by a leader, Wright and Bergman Rosamond (2021) demonstrates that similar public diplomacy effort by the NATO when it invited Angelina Jolie to NATO in an attempt to raise awareness of gender justice.

Relatedly, visits by prominent individuals provide an opportunity to transnational advocacy networks and other stakeholders to rally around various causes. When Pope Francis announced his plan to visit Mozambique in 2019, a group of human rights organizations, including Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch, penned an open letter to him to bring attention to "a number of human rights issues of concern" and to urge him to use his visit "as an opportunity to publicly support their call for the protection and promotion of human rights (Amnesty International 2019)." Similarly, when the UNSG released his schedule to visit Lebanon, human rights organizations sent a letter to highlight human rights concerns in Lebanon (Choi et al. 2023).

Existing Studies on Visits by Leaders of Non-State Entities

The literature on causes and consequences of visits by leaders of non-state entities is nascent yet growing. In addition to published works to date, there are some known ongoing data building projects that attempt to provide detailed information on visits by non-state leaders.

Earlier works focus on leader of religious organizations, including the leader of Tibetan Buddhism, the Dalai Lama, and that of Catholic Church, Pope Francis and Pope John Paul II. Given the conflictual relationship between the Dalai Lama and the Chinese government, studies on the Dalai Lama try to empirically examine how receiving the Dalai Lama would produce some unintended consequences. Fuchs and Klann (2013) demonstrate that countries where government officials, such as the head of state, receive the Dalai Lama experience a decline in exports to China. The decline in exports is also observed at a firm-level analysis (Lin, Hu, and Fuchs 2019). Contrary to the "Dalai Lama" effect, Sverdrup-Thygeson (2015) reports that when the 2010 Nobel Peace Prize laureate and a vocal critic of China, Liu Xiaobo, visited Norway and met with Norwegian politicians, Norwegian exports to China were unaffected by the visit.

Pope Francis has received some attention as well. As the authoritative figure of the Catholic Church, his visits to countries tend to receive intensified media coverage and hence provide him an excellent opportunity to highlight various social causes, including the environment and human rights. Dubbed as the "Pope Francis effect," US citizens are more likely to recognize climate as a pressing moral issue after Pope Francis sent an encyclical letter in 2015 and when they are briefly exposed to Pope Francis's message (Schuldt et al. 2017; Landrum and Vasquez 2020). A more straightforward examination of visits by the Catholic Pope, Endrich and Gutmann (2024) demonstrate that human rights conditions in a visited state improve right before a visit happens and do not regress back to the original level

once he leaves the country. Laville (2021) examines the effect of Pope John Paul II's visits and reaches the conclusion that visits by John Paul II decrease the risk of conflict in host countries, especially when host countries have small Catholic populations.

More recent studies attempt to examine one of the most prominent individuals in international affairs, the UNSG. Choi et al. (2023) and Choi et al. (2024) attempt to theorize why UNSGs visit some countries but not others and what consequences those visits bring about. Utilizing the original dataset covering the UNSGs for the past 25 years, Mr. Kofi Annan, Mr. Ki-moon Ban, and Mr. Antonio Guterres, Choi et al. (2023) demonstrate that when a country receives a visit by a UNSG, that country's human rights conditions tend to improve dramatically. Choi et al. (2024) also show that when a UNSG visits a developing country, the country is likely to receive more multilateral aid from multilateral development agencies.

Bell and Kitagawa (2024) put together an original dataset covering in-country visits by the OHCHR and examine how the OHCHR selects where to visit. Their analysis shows that while the OHCHR targets countries with poor human rights conditions, it also visits countries with greater repression, with existing UN peacekeeping operations, and with democratization episodes. This study is especially notable in that it is one of the first studies that attempts to explain what factors are considered when the OHCHR selects a country to visit.

Implications for Future Research

The recent attention given to state visits by leaders of non-state entities is a certainly welcoming development. With original data-building efforts, these studies provide empirical evidence that visits by non-state entities' leaders do make differences and produce intended and unintended outcomes.

Given the nascent nature of the literature, there are plenty of opportunities for interested scholars for future research. For instance, there are untapped prominent individuals, such as the President of the World Bank or the Managing Director of the International Monetary Fund, who might exert substantial influence when they take state visits, especially in their specialized issue areas. Because the organizations that they represent command financial resources and expertise in economic policies, for instance, the leaders of the international financial institutions might have greater potential to influence visited states' economies, but they might also produce unintended consequences. Leaders of regional international organizations likewise might exert certain influence, especially in their own regions. In addition, leaders and individuals representing non-governmental organizations for the environment or human rights might also make meaningful differences. Lastly, leaders of transnational ethnic groups or terrorist organizations might travel for certain political and social causes and thus merit scholarly attention. The key criteria for those who can exert substantial influence as a leader of a non-state entity may be (i) the authority that they command by being perceived as impartial, ethical, or expert, and (ii) their ability to grab the public's attention.

Moving forward, the literature would benefit from explicit theorization of which countries are chosen for visits before examining consequences of these visits. Outside of the couple of studies mentioned above (e.g., Choi et al. 2023; Bell and Kitagawa 2024), there are few studies that theorize why certain countries are chosen for a visit. As leaders of non-state entities represent organizations that have their set of goals, different considerations might be given when they plan for official visits. Relatedly, because the main contribution of this literature seems to be empirical at the moment, the literature would greatly benefit by building a theoretical link between how visits are planned and what consequences those visits produce. In addition, exploring the temporal dynamics of visits and their subsequent effect might be worthwhile.

Expanding the Lens on Leader Interactions: A Network Approach to Leader Visits

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While extensive scholarship has advanced our understanding of the determinants and impacts of leader visits, most studies conceptualize these visits within a dyadic framework, focusing primarily on direct interactions between the host and sending states (e.g., [Lebovic and Saunders 2016](#); [Ostrander and Rider 2019](#); [Koliev and Lundgren 2021](#); [Malis and Smith 2021](#)). However, such approaches often overlook the broader relational dynamics that shape these interactions, as well as the ripple effects that bilateral interactions generate within the broader network.

This essay introduces a network perspective to better understand the determinants and implications of leader visits. Leader visits do not occur in isolation; rather, they are embedded within a larger network of interdependent state leaders. A state's decision to arrange leader visits and select diplomatic partners is shaped not only by bilateral relations but also by the broader network structure, where states observe, respond to, and align their visit patterns with third-party states. Likewise, the effects of these visits often extend beyond the host and sending states, influencing third-party states through diffusion and socialization mechanisms. Thus, leader visits shape regional and global diplomatic alignments beyond bilateral relationships. Network analysis provides theoretical insights and highlights potential empirical applications that conventional bilateral analyses overlook.

To fully appreciate the value of a network perspective, it is essential to define what constitutes a network. Networks are defined as sets of ties (relationships or links) between nodes (agents or actors). In the context of leader-visit networks, nodes represent state leaders, and links are formed when one leader visits another. These links function as channels for both material resources (e.g., weapons, money) and non-material resources (e.g., information, beliefs, norms) ([Hafner-Burton, Kahler, and Montgomery 2009](#)). By transmitting these resources, leader visits shape regional and global diplomatic alignments, fostering cooperation or competition. In addition to revealing hidden patterns of interdependence, network analysis provides valuable empirical tools. It offers measures of key network structures, such as state positions and community structures, as well as inferential techniques that account for dependencies among states ([Hafner-Burton, Kahler, and Montgomery 2009](#); [Maoz 2012](#)).

Network analysis provides three key insights into the dynamics of leader visits. First, it highlights higher-order relationships beyond direct host-sender interactions as key determinants of leader visits. Since states often lack information on which visits will yield benefits or provoke retaliation, they frequently take cues from their own diplomatic partners ([Kinne 2014](#); [Duque 2018](#)). To minimize risks, states may align their visits with allies or diplomatic partners, reducing chances of negative repercussions ([Kinne 2014](#)). This strategic alignment suggests a “friends of friends” or transitivity mechanism, where states model their visits on those of their partners.

For instance, President Nixon's 1972 visit to the People's Republic of China (PRC) signaled to allied states—such as the United Kingdom, Japan, and Australia—to follow suit and switch their diplomatic recognition. Japanese Prime Minister Tanaka visited the PRC in September 1972, Australian Prime Minister Whitlam in November 1973, and British Prime Minister Edward Heath in January 1974. This move prompted additional countries, including those in the Pacific Islands and Latin America, to follow suit, accelerating the process—whether the United States intended this outcome ([Choi 2024](#)). Similarly, President Biden's visit to Kyiv

in February 2023 sent a message not only to Ukraine but also to its allied countries, signaling that “Kyiv is still a go-to destination for international democratic leaders” (Faraponov 2023). Biden’s visit encouraged further diplomatic engagement, as seen when Japanese Prime Minister Kishida visited Ukraine soon after.

Second, network analysis can reveal communities of leaders in a way that is both empirically rigorous and substantively meaningful. Employing community detection methods in leader-visit networks can identify clusters of leaders who engage in frequent visits among themselves. These methods are empirically rigorous because they do not rely on pre-determined variables, such as leaders’ nationalities or the political and economic systems of their states (e.g., Lupu and Traag 2013; Renshon 2016; Choi 2021). While previous research often relies on geographic proximity or shared memberships in international organizations to define communities (e.g., Hellmann 1969; Thompson 1981b), network analysis can identify clusters based solely on actual leader visits. From a network perspective, these interconnected relationships are central to the concept of belonging to a community. These clusters are constructed and evolving rather than predetermined or fixed. Thus, analyzing how clusters within leader-visit networks evolve over time reveals the extent to which global diplomatic engagement becomes fragmented or integrated.

Third, network analysis provides deeper insight into how bilateral leader visits create ripple effects through diffusion and socialization to third-party states (Zhukov and Stewart 2013). When a sending state prioritizes one country over others in a region, it can indirectly influence neighboring states’ behavior and strategic choices. By observing the substantial benefits of leader visits—such as foreign aid (Hoshiro 2020), bilateral trade stimulation (Lin, Yan, and Wang 2017), and foreign direct investment (Adam and Tsarsitalidou 2024)—neighboring states may adjust their policies to attract similar diplomatic attention. For instance, Chen (2023) finds that Chinese leaders’ visits not only directly foster foreign policy alignment between China and host countries but also induce policy alignment in neighboring countries. While leader visits are often designed to promote bilateral relationships, their influence often extends to include neighboring states (Chen 2023; Balci 2024a). Community detection methods are especially useful in this context, as they can identify clusters of states susceptible to these socialization and diffusion effects.

A recent surge in leader visits from both the global West and East to the global South is driven in part by socialization and diffusion effects. Although the primary struggle over world order lies between the West and East, the global South plays a pivotal role as a “swing grouping,” capable of influencing the global order through its alignments (Ikenberry 2024, 131). As a critical third party shaping global public opinion—and, by extension, the evolving global order—securing support from the global South has become increasingly important. In this vein, Russian officials have made numerous visits to countries in Africa, Latin America, and Asia, aiming to garner support for Russia’s war⁵ (The Economist 2022; Caballero 2023). When Russia visits Brazil, it may leverage diffusion effects to further advance its preferences in Latin America. Similarly, the United States and Europe are actively seeking to secure backing from the global South in defense of Ukraine, hoping to trigger similar diffusion effects (Ikenberry 2024). Leader visits to specific countries in Africa, Latin America, and Asia can extend their influence beyond bilateral ties, making network analysis essential for understanding these dynamics. Network analysis helps explain how this geopolitical competition evolves over time and shapes global order.

Despite the valuable insights network analysis can offer, few studies have examined the determinants and implications of leader visits from a network perspective, and empirical analysis on this topic is particularly lacking. This gap stems

⁵In 2023, Russian officials visited Angola, Burundi, Eritrea, Eswatini, Kenya, Mali, Mauritania, Mozambique, South Africa, and Sudan. That same year, Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov toured parts of Latin America, visiting Brazil, Venezuela, Nicaragua, and Cuba (Caballero 2023).

largely from the lack of comprehensive time-series and cross-sectional data on high-level leader visits across all states. Nonetheless, some notable studies have collected data and examined leader visits by specific countries, such as the United States (Ostrander and Rider 2019), China (Wang and Stone 2023), and Turkey (Balci and Pulat 2024). Analyzing these cases from a network perspective can significantly enrich the literature by identifying which countries hold greater political significance for these countries and revealing how these dynamics have evolved over time. Expanding this foundation, more comprehensive data encompassing all countries' leader visits could significantly advance the study of leader visits. By shifting the analytical lens from bilateral interactions to broader diplomatic networks, this discussion provides a conceptual foundation for future studies employing network methods to study leader visits.

Rethinking Leader Visits as Performances

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Introduction

June 6, 2024, marked the 80th anniversary of D-Day. To commemorate the event, world leaders joined veterans in Normandy, France, to remember the sacrifice of allied forces in a critical battle of the Second World War. Unlike his foreign counterparts, however, UK Prime Minister Rishi Sunak left the event early for a television interview for the UK general election. The move quickly proved to be a painful error. Sunak faced blistering criticism—including from his own party—over what was seen as an opportunistic exit from an important event. Although Sunak apologized, the damage had already been done.

Conventional studies of leader visits can tell us many important things. They can tell us the determinants of leader visits (Lebovic and Saunders 2016), their role in strategies of deterrence (McManus 2018), and even important regional variations (Balci and Pulat 2024). But what they cannot tell us is why Sunak was so wounded by leaving early. Instead, understanding Sunak's error requires us to appreciate leader visits as performances. Sunak was engaged in a specific performance, a remembrance ritual, focused on honoring the sacrifices of the allied forces. Yet, in deciding to leave early, he presented an image of insincerity, and audiences interpreted this as the mark of an incompetent performer. This transgression triggered anger and admonishment, ultimately leading to an embarrassing apology.

In this brief contribution, we make the case for understanding leader visits as performances. We do not disagree that the decision to visit is informed by strategic and domestic interests; we only claim that these performances are politically significant in their own right. This is because leader visits are where small performative acts—a friendly embrace, a sharp insult, a moment of senility—can ripple into much larger domestic and international consequences. As individuals who personify states and stand in for them on the diplomatic stage (Ku and Mitzen 2022), the performance of leaders is subject to intense observation by foreign governments, as well as domestic and foreign publics. To better understand how and why these performances

matter, we suggest focusing on two levels of analysis: the micro-level of the leader's facework and the macro-level of audience reception.

The Micro-Level

To understand performances, our point of departure is [Erving Goffman's \(1967\)](#) view of facework. For Goffman, every social interaction sees participants working to project a positive public image or "face." This face has strategic and social value because it conveys desirable attributes such as competence, status, and prestige. More than this, however, a participant's face is a key source of their sense of self ([1967, 31](#)). When facework falters, cracks in this image become apparent, and participants can suffer shame and embarrassment. To protect against this, participants engage in facework aimed at "saving face."

Leader visits are a distinctive kind of facework. Leaders make claims, enact roles, signal values, engage in gestures (e.g., handshakes), partake in rituals, and express emotions—all calibrated toward the performance of a specific face. On the one hand, this facework presents leaders as individuals. Leaders are highly conscious of their personal image during these visits, both for how it will be read as evidence of their intentions and sincerity by other leaders ([Holmes and Wheeler 2020](#)) and for how the visit might elevate (or damage) their personal political standing. The result is that leaders become personally invested in their performances—both politically and emotionally—and this captures an important "human factor" in world politics often elided by structural theorizing ([Wheeler 2018](#)). On the other hand, however, this facework also presents leaders as states. When Russian Prime Minister Vladimir Putin warmly embraced Polish prime minister Donald Tusk in 2010 and expressed his sympathies for the death of Tusk's successor in a plane crash, it created an image of not just a sympathetic Putin, but of a sympathetic Russia ([Hall 2016, 13–4](#)). Because of their authoritative position, leaders have a central role in deciding what kind of image a state projects, and they are often the central figure in the performance of that image ([Hall 2016, 23–4](#)).

But cannot we just dismiss these performances as little more than cheap talk? The problem with this argument is that leaders themselves often do not seem to think so. As Balci notes in this forum's introduction, leaders are increasingly using one of their most precious resources—time—to engage in these visits. More generally, states invest significant time and energy in organizing visits, with summits like the G7 requiring a small army of diplomatic, logistic, and security personnel ([Naylor 2024](#)).

These performances, however, are not without risks. When US president Biden accidentally introduced Ukrainian president Zelensky as "Putin," it was a cringe-worthy gaffe that reinforced the growing perception of his senility. Leaders can misspeak, stutter, forget names, fall ill, suffer jet lag, or simply give an incompetent performance that undermines the "face" they hope to project. But damage to one's face can also be intentional and strategic. Leaders can use put-downs ([Wong 2021](#)), insults ([Rousseau and Baele 2021](#)), mockery ([Van Rythoven 2022](#)), and other kinds of aggressive face work to undermine one another's image or even to attack leaders who are not present. These episodes of symbolic violence can have lasting psychological effects on the leaders involved and even signal a deepening estrangement between countries.

The Macro-Level

For Goffman, every figure seeks to project a positive face, but their success depends on their audience. Whether a leader succeeds in giving a "good showing" of themselves, as [Goffman \(1967, 5\)](#) describes it, depends on how audiences receive their performance. In the case of leader visits, multiple audiences matter, as it falls on

foreign governments, as well as domestic and foreign publics, to “read” the performance of high-level diplomacy (Cohen 1987). Different audiences, however, can hold different standards for what constitutes a competent performance (cf. Adler and Pouliot 2011, 7). Our macro-level analysis focuses on the audiences’ reception of leader visits because this is where they can generate broader domestic and international effects.

One of the most visible effects is when a leader’s performance is offensive. In most cases leaders carefully calibrate their performance to avoid offending their hosts as well as foreign publics. But when leaders are inexperienced or ignorant of the local context, they risk violating the local standards of propriety. While visiting Myanmar, UK Foreign Secretary Boris Johnson traveled to the Shwedagon Pagoda, a sacred Buddhist site in Yangon, and began to recite the colonial-era poem *Mandalay*. The poem not only evokes memories of Britain’s former colonial rule but also contains derogatory references to Buddhism in a majority-Buddhist country. Recognizing the danger of offending their hosts, the British ambassador quickly warned Johnson that “You’re on mic” and that his comments were “Not appropriate” (Randerson 2017). Johnson’s co-performer stepped in to help prevent offense and save face.

In most cases the effects of leader visits are more positive with leaders engaging in facework that conveys esteem and gratitude for their hosts. South Korean presidents’ visits to Washington often involve visiting sites representing the historical underpinnings of the South Korea–US alliance, such as the Korean War Memorial and the Arlington Cemetery. In 2023, Presidents Yoon and Biden, joined by their spouses, made a public visit to the Korean War Memorial, where they stood for a moment of silence—a gesture of respect easily recognizable to an American audience. These kinds of public activities can produce positive public diplomacy effects (Goldsmith, Horiuchi, and Matush 2021) and, in the case of South Korea, help affirm the country’s unwavering commitment as an important East Asian partner.

One of the most important effects of these performances is the political symbolism they generate. President Biden’s “surprise” visit to Kyiv, Ukraine, in February 2023, in conjunction with the first anniversary of Russia’s invasion, underscored the US’s support to maintain allies’ support for Ukraine. The symbolism of the US president making a dangerous trip to an embattled foreign capital was enthusiastically received by Ukrainians. In other cases, even mundane visits can have important symbolic effects. The United States and the Republic of Ireland have created a tradition where the Irish Taoiseach presents a bowl of shamrocks to the US president, symbolizing the longstanding friendship between the two countries.

While leaders will try and control the impressions generated by their performances, there is always the possibility for unintended consequences. Because visits are primarily elite-staged performances, they generate a political space for audiences to publicly embrace or criticize the performance (Ku 2022). For instance, South Korean President Yoon Suk-yeol’s singing of “American Pie” during the state dinner at the White House in April 2023 was well received in the United States, while some in South Korea saw it as unseemly. Similarly, Japanese President Shinzo Abe’s lavish praise of President Trump in 2016 was warmly received by the Trump administration but was seen as humiliating by some in Japan. Performances that are well received abroad can end up generating criticism at home.

Given the publicness of visits and the multiplicity of audiences, managing audience reception is challenging. Regardless of the amount of preparation, leaders will likely face criticisms from domestic political opponents, especially if the performance is seen as working against state interests. As with all performances, multiple interpretations by audiences abound. What leaders can do is complement their performances with verbal expressions to minimize misunderstandings and misinterpretations. The flip side, however, is that a successful performance, one that caters to the domestic audiences’ needs and desires but also reassures allies and friends, will

bring a far greater payoff to leaders and governments than simple verbal expressions of promoting foreign policy do.

Conclusion

Leader visits are often treated as a barometer of a country's diplomatic, alliance, and trade ties. In contrast, we see visits as politically significant in their own right, as the performances they entail can ripple into much larger domestic and international consequences. More than just an indicator of state relations, such visits are where much of the "politics" of diplomatic relations actually takes place.

What might a research agenda focused on visits as performances look like? Space limits our answer, but we argue one possible research program would be focused on mapping the performative repertoire of leaders' visits using interpretive methods and in-depth qualitative case analysis of visits to trace how visits are staged and to identify the conditions under which certain performances generate acceptance or controversy by domestic and foreign audiences. What patterns of facework do leaders engage in, and why? Why does this repertoire remain relatively stable in some periods while changing in others? How do gender and class shape the performative repertoire of leaders? How do technologies like social media affect this repertoire? Finally, how do leaders adapt their repertoire to new challenges—such as populist disruption? Such studies would tell us not only why leaders engage with these performances but also why they continue to matter on the global stage.

The Future of Studying Leader Visits in International Relations

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Throughout history, leader visits have played a pivotal role in shaping international political outcomes. From high-stakes summits that averted conflicts to state visits that expressed resolve, the physical presence of leaders has often served as a catalyst for political transformations. This forum has brought together a diverse array of perspectives, methodologies, and findings, illuminating the multifaceted nature of leader visits and their profound impact on global politics.

As the contributions in this forum point out, despite the advancements in technology and the rise of virtual communication platforms, the fundamental importance of face-to-face interactions in diplomacy remains (Holmes and Wheeler 2020; Holmes and Wheeler 2023; Holmes 2025). Just as Ronald Reagan and Mikhail Gorbachev found that personal meetings were indispensable in creating a social bond that included trust, helping to ease Cold War tensions (Wheeler 2018), contemporary leaders continue to recognize the unique value that in-person engagements bring to diplomacy and continue to travel the globe, often at considerable cost, in order to engage with others. The question, then, is not whether leader visits matter—they clearly do—but rather how we can deepen our understanding of both when and why leaders travel and those interactions' specific effects.

Challenges in Translating Leader Visits into Sustainable Diplomatic Outcomes

While leader visits and face-to-face diplomacy hold significant promise in transforming adversarial relationships, several challenges persist in leveraging leader visits to achieve lasting international cooperation. Three critical issues stand out: the aggre-

gation problem, the development of security dilemma sensibility (SDS), and integrating leader visits with emerging communication technologies.

The Aggregation Problem: Scaling Interpersonal Trust to the State Level

One of the fundamental challenges to high-level visits is the so-called aggregation problem, which refers to the difficulty of translating personal rapport between leaders into broader policy changes and sustainable peace. While leaders may develop mutual trust during their visits, this trust often does not permeate the wider governmental structures or alter entrenched bureaucratic interests, sometimes leaving state relations distinct from personal relations.

A notable example is the relationship between Pakistani Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto and Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in the late 1980s ([Holmes and Wheeler forthcoming](#)). Their personal diplomacy, including a series of meetings and the initiation of confidence-building measures, signaled a mutual desire to improve relations between the two countries. Bhutto and Gandhi shared a personal rapport and even discussed the possibility of resolving longstanding issues such as the Siachen Glacier conflict and nuclear proliferation. However, despite their genuine efforts, domestic political pressures, military skepticism, and bureaucratic inertia in both countries hindered the translation of their personal trust into substantive policy changes. This example illustrates the aggregation problem, where the inability to align personal relationships with institutional policies and broader governmental support limits the impact of leader visits on achieving lasting diplomatic outcomes.

Addressing the aggregation problem requires creating channels through which interpersonal trust can influence policy. Robert [Putnam \(1988\)](#) argued that policymakers play “two-level games,” negotiating international agreements and domestic acceptance. The issue is not just legislation but transforming state relationships from enmity to amity. Establishing joint institutions, engaging civil society, and involving multiple levels of government can help embed the trust developed between leaders into the fabric of state policies.

Developing Security Dilemma Sensibility: Bridging Mutual Insecurities

An ongoing challenge in international relations lies in understanding why some leaders develop SDS and effectively communicate this recognition to their counterparts, while others cannot. SDS entails not only recognizing that one’s actions may contribute to an adversary’s insecurity but also having the willingness to take steps to mitigate those concerns ([Booth and Wheeler 2008](#)). SDS can be divided into two types: inward SDS and outward SDS ([Wheeler and Holmes 2022](#)). Inward SDS refers to a leader’s capacity to understand that their own actions and policies contribute to the adversary’s sense of threat, recognizing themselves as part of the problem. Outward SDS, on the other hand, refers to a leader’s perception or intuition that their adversary also has the capacity for SDS—that the other side recognizes its own role in the security dilemma and is capable of reciprocating with reassurance.

Leaders like Ronald Reagan and Mikhail Gorbachev exemplified both inward and outward SDS during the latter stages of the Cold War. Reagan, in particular, transitioned from aggressive rhetoric to a more conciliatory approach, gaining an understanding of Soviet security concerns and acknowledging the role of US policies in amplifying Soviet fears. This inward SDS enabled Reagan to approach Gorbachev with genuine intentions of reassurance. Furthermore, Reagan’s intuition that Gorbachev also possessed SDS—the outward dimension—allowed for the establishment of mutual trust and meaningful diplomacy. This mutual recognition created the conditions for reassurance diplomacy, where each leader could see the

other's actions as genuine efforts to reduce tensions rather than as attempts to gain a strategic advantage.

In contrast, during the 1961 Vienna Summit, US President John F. Kennedy and Soviet Premier Nikita Khrushchev exemplified a lack of both inward and outward SDS, leading to mutual misjudgments and heightened tensions. Kennedy's inability to convey an understanding of Soviet insecurities, combined with Khrushchev's aggressive posture, illustrated the relative absence of SDS on both sides. With little inward SDS, Kennedy struggled to see how American policies might threaten Soviet security. Lacking outward SDS, Khrushchev was unable to believe that Kennedy was capable of recognizing Soviet concerns, viewing Kennedy's moves through a lens of distrust. This mutual shortfall hindered their ability to communicate reassurance.

Understanding these differences may involve combining experimental methods and quantitative analysis with deep qualitative studies of leaders' personalities and backgrounds. Kertzer et al. (2024) explore the microfoundations of the security dilemma by conducting parallel cross-national survey experiments in China and the United States. Their research demonstrates that the psychological biases underlying the security dilemma are present in both Chinese and American publics. Notably, they find that perspective-taking—often suggested as a means to mitigate misunderstandings—does not always have the intended calming effect and can sometimes backfire when individuals perceive threats to their identity and goals. This suggests that cross-cultural differences and psychological factors significantly affect diplomatic interactions and that efforts to enhance mutual understanding must be carefully tailored to account for these complexities.

Integrating Leader Visits with Emerging Communication Technologies

Finally, the rise of communication technologies like Zoom, virtual reality, and secure hotlines presents both opportunities and challenges for leader visits. The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the adoption of virtual meetings, forcing diplomats and leaders to rely heavily on digital platforms to maintain international engagements. While these tools have enabled continuity in global dialogue, questions remain about their effectiveness compared to in-person interactions.

Research suggests that while teleconferencing platforms such as Zoom facilitate communication, they may not fully replicate the nuances of face-to-face meetings. Non-verbal cues, body language, and the capacity for spontaneous interactions are often diminished in virtual settings (Holmes and Wheeler 2023). Participants often experience "Zoom fatigue" due to the cognitive load of compensating for missing non-verbal signals, which can reduce engagement and effectiveness (Bailenson 2021). This limitation can impact the ability to build trust and deeply understand intentions, which are crucial components of successful diplomacy.

Emerging technologies like virtual and augmented reality (VR/AR) offer promising solutions by creating immersive environments that mimic real-world interactions. VR/AR can enhance presence, allowing participants to feel as if they're in the same room, capturing non-verbal cues like facial expressions and gestures (Bailenson 2018). These platforms can simulate informal settings, facilitating side conversations and "corridor diplomacy" difficult in standard video conferencing (Naylor 2020). Features like haptic feedback can simulate tactile sensations, fostering deeper connections.

However, integrating these technologies requires considering accessibility, security, privacy, and cultural acceptance. Technical infrastructure varies, and some societies may prefer traditional face-to-face interactions. Effectiveness may depend on existing relationships; VR/AR might work best after trust has been established in person. Ongoing research is needed to understand their impact on communication dynamics (Holmes and Kaplow 2025). Understanding how to integrate these technologies requires ongoing research into their impact on communication

dynamics. By exploring how AI-enhanced predictive analytics and VR/AR platforms influence cooperative behavior and intention understanding, diplomats can better tailor their strategies to leverage the strengths of both traditional and emerging communication methods. This includes considering ergonomic design for comfort during extended use, ensuring high-resolution visuals and realistic avatars, and incorporating cultural and accessibility considerations to make the technology inclusive and effective.

In conclusion, while virtual technologies cannot fully replace the richness of face-to-face diplomacy, advancements in VR/AR hold the potential to supplement traditional methods, especially when physical meetings are impractical. By embracing these innovations thoughtfully and addressing the associated challenges, leaders can enhance their ability to communicate effectively, build trust, and manage international relations in an increasingly digital world.

Conclusion

Leader visits remain a critical yet under-theorized dimension of international relations. While scholars have long studied diplomatic summits and high-level negotiations, the unique impact of physical presence—how it shapes interpersonal trust, strategic signaling, and crisis management—deserves further scrutiny. This forum has made clear that leader visits are sites of political meaning-making that can recalibrate relationships between states.

Going forward, the study of leader visits should address three pressing research questions. First, how does the durability of trust forged in leader visits vary across political systems? While much of the literature has focused on the aggregation problem—how interpersonal trust is scaled to the state level—there is a need to integrate leadership duration and regime type into this framework. Do democratic leaders struggle more than autocrats to sustain trust because of electoral cycles? How do leader visits function in systems where power transitions are uncertain or contested? Future work should explore the intersection of personal rapport, institutional mechanisms, and political longevity.

Second, how are shifting geopolitical and ideological dynamics reshaping the patterns of leader visits? As US–China and US–Russia tensions deepen, are leader visits becoming more polarized along geopolitical lines? Are ideological divisions leading leaders to engage primarily with like-minded counterparts, reinforcing blocs rather than bridging divides? Systematic mapping of visit patterns could reveal whether face-to-face diplomacy is now more about signaling than genuine engagement. At the same time, leader visits may carry risks, especially for allies. The 2025 Trump–Zelensky meeting at the White House, which publicly humiliated Zelensky and cast doubt on US support for Ukraine, illustrates how face-to-face diplomacy can backfire. Under certain conditions, high-level visits may expose weaker states to power plays and political spectacle. Future research should examine whether allied leaders are recalibrating their approach to face-to-face diplomacy to mitigate these risks.

Third, how do different modes of leader communication—letters, phone calls, video conferences, and emerging technologies—compare in their ability to build trust and convey intentions? While this forum has explored the implications of virtual diplomacy, there is relatively little systematic research on how different mediums shape leader interactions. Phone calls, for instance, remain a staple of crisis diplomacy, but how do they compare with face-to-face meetings or video exchanges in terms of reducing misperceptions and enabling reassurance? Understanding these differences is critical as digital technologies become more integrated into diplomatic practice.

Ultimately, the future of studying leader visits lies in moving beyond the broad question of whether they matter to examining the conditions under which they are effective, enduring, and transformative. This requires blending historical case

studies with experimental and computational methods, linking individual psychology with structural forces, and critically assessing how new technologies reshape what it means for leaders to meet. If diplomacy is, at its core, a process of human interaction, then the study of leader visits must remain central to understanding global politics in the twenty-first century.

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